Donovan Ellison

dvaneson@gmail.com dvaneson.com Donovan Ellison dvaneson

SKILLS

Technologies: AWS, GCP, Github Actions, Helm, Docker, Kubernetes, Terraform, and Jenkins

Programming: Go, Python, CSS, HTML, and JavaScript

Certifications: GIAC Cloud Security Automation Certification (GCSA)

EXPERIENCE

Security Engineer, *Ontra*

Sep 2024 — Present

- Automated vulnerability management with an event-driven pipeline that tracked 1,000+ vulnerability findings from 5+ sources, set SLA due dates, routed vulnerabilities to owning teams, and auto-closed 242 tickets on scanner fix or triage events.
- Built an AI vulnerability triage agent (Claude Code sub-agents, Semgrep and Jira APIs, human approval gate) that drafted decisions on 438 tickets in 6 months as quarterly intake rose ~13x, screening out false positives (60%) before they reached engineering teams.
- Partnered with Infrastructure on a service-mesh and Gateway API migration for east-west mTLS. Analyzed gateway benchmarks to steer controller selection, co-built Linkerd and Kgateway proofs of concept, and upgraded the Calico operator.
- Owned the Rad Security runtime agent on 10 production and staging AWS EKS clusters, keeping Kubernetes threat detection and audit logging current through 12 merged Helm and Terraform PRs.
- Built and operated an open-source threat modeling app on EKS and RDS using Terraform, Helm, GitHub Actions, and Okta OIDC; after an adoption review, replaced it with a lightweight Notion workflow that supported 30+ threat models in its first year.
- Responded to the November 2025 Shai-Hulud campaign by writing and deploying a Semgrep rule that blocked its indicator files the day it was announced.
- Built a script to check Semgrep's dependency inventory against compromised-package lists, using it during subsequent mini-Shai-Hulud and Axios compromises; also moved Semgrep's run-shell-injection rule into blocking mode to harden CI/CD against the exploited vulnerability.

Senior Cloud Security Engineer, *apree health*

Mar 2024 — Sep 2024

- Optimized Terraform pipelines, decreasing approval and request processing times by over 80%, enhancing efficiency and usability for both approvers and requesters.
- Partnered with engineering teams to deploy Renovate across 100+ repositories, automating dependency management. This proactive approach mitigated Critical and High vulnerabilities in over 50 production services, significantly enhancing security posture.
- Facilitated the deployment of a self-service access portal, resulting in a 66% reduction in group request completion times and ensuring adherence to SOC II and HITRUST access controls.
- Streamlined and optimized the setup and coordination of AWS and GCP pentests, reducing the overall setup time by 50%.

Cloud Security Engineer, *apree health* **Jan 2022 — Mar 2024**

- As the inaugural Cloud Security Engineer, led security initiatives throughout a year-and-a-half long data center migration to GCP.
- Enforced CIS standards with Policy-as-Code for hundreds of GCP projects, ensuring compliance with encryption key usage and preventing misconfigurations such as publicly accessible GCS buckets.
- Successfully implemented egress filtering for URLs in PHI environments, a pivotal step in achieving HITRUST certification.
- Orchestrated the deployment of DiscrimiNAT across 6 VPCs, effectively filtering traffic in 27 environments with over 900 unique FQDNs.
- Developed a Python Flask app that enables developers to bypass the 24-hour SLA for FQDN additions by quickly creating temporary egress firewall rules in lower environments. This innovation saved thousands of engineering hours, allowing uninterrupted development and testing.
- Introduced sprint planning, backlog grooming, and retrospective sessions, resulting in an outstanding 77% reduction in Lead Time for ticket completion, from an average of 61.3 days to just 13.8 days after 3 months.

Site Reliability Engineer, *Zapproved* **Mar 2021 — Jan 2022**

- Enabled AWS Systems Manager for several dozen EC2 instances, providing secure remote command execution, automated patching, and granular access control to instances.
- Architected an AWS solution for managing SSH keys on TeamCity agents across multiple AWS accounts, enhancing security and access management.
- Analyzed and resolved an Elasticsearch cluster issue that caused day long logging outages, sometimes multiple times a week.
- Spearheaded the refactoring of the AWS Elastic Kubernetes Service (EKS) provisioning and configuration.
- Developed a roadmap for Kubernetes improvements by evaluating different tools, researching best practices, creating proof of concepts, and meeting with key stakeholders.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science in **Computer Science, University Honors** **Sep 2016 — Aug 2020**

Portland State University